

AN ORIGINAL ANIME FEATURE FILM · INDIA × JAPAN

THE RIVER REMEMBERS

河は憶えている

नदी को याद है · நதிக்கு நினைவிருக்கிறது

*When a grieving veena prodigy in Chennai and a reluctant shrine heir in Enoshima strike the same note 6,000 kilometres apart, they wake a fading goddess with two names — **Saraswati** in India, **Benzaiten** in Japan — and have one festival night to finish the song she has carried between their countries for 1,300 years.*

FEATURE FILM · ≈110 MIN · 2D HAND-DRAWN · SUBMISSION: PROPOSAL + CONCEPT TEASER
(VIDEO)

One song, two shores 一つの歌、二つの岸

A goddess is a song the world keeps singing. When the world stops — she vanishes.

Meera Iyer, seventeen, was Chennai's brightest young veena prodigy — until her grandmother-guru died mid-lesson, and the music stopped with her. Now she edits lo-fi beats at 2 a.m., built around one secret sample: her grandmother's last recording.

Six thousand kilometres away, on the island of Enoshima, **Kaito Amamiya** practises the biwa only because someone must — he is the reluctant heir to a tiny shrine of Benzaiten, and what he truly loves is field recording: the sound of places no one listens to.

One night his recording of the shrine at dawn meets her grandmother's veena inside a 2 a.m. mix — and the two sounds **resonate**. In both countries at once, a goddess wakes: **Saras** — Saraswati to Meera, Benzaiten to Kaito — the goddess of music, rivers and knowledge who

crossed the sea with the sutras 1,300 years ago, and who has been fading ever since the world stopped listening.

Worse — something has been feeding on the forgetting. **Mauna, the Silence**, is swallowing sound itself: a drumbeat here, a temple bell there. Saras will be next.

A girl who won't play, a boy who never wanted to, and a goddess who is forgetting her own name have one spring to compose the **Bridge Raga** — a single melody built from the notes their two musics share — and perform it where her invisible river once flowed. They cannot even speak each other's language. But music doesn't ask.

On **Vasant Panchami**, at the meeting of three rivers, they will teach the silence to listen.

Format. Theatrical feature, ≈110 minutes · 2D hand-drawn with digital compositing · Dual-language conceit (Tamil/English × Japanese; the leads can only truly "speak" through music) · Audience: the worldwide theatrical anime audience of music-driven, mythology-rooted films — and both home markets at once. Series expansion possible (12 × 24 min).

The gods already made this crossing

The film's fantasy is real history: in the 8th century, Hindu deities sailed to Japan inside Buddhist sutras — and stayed.

Every Japanese child knows Benzaiten, goddess of music and water, enshrined on islands like Enoshima. Few remember she is **Saraswati**, who crossed from India with the sutras and the lutes. She is not the only traveller:

INDIA		JAPAN
Saraswati सरस्वती	→	Benzaiten 弁財天
Lakshmi लक्ष्मी	→	Kichijōten 吉祥天
Ganesha गणेश	→	Kangiten 歓喜天
Yama यम	→	Enma 閻魔
Brahma ब्रह्मा	→	Bonten 梵天

Our premise simply takes this literally: **the goddess has lived stretched between two shores for thirteen centuries.** In India her river — the Saraswati — vanished millennia ago; myth says it still flows unseen, joining the Ganga

and Yamuna at Triveni Sangam. In Japan her islands still ring with bells. A goddess split between a river no one can see and bells no one hears.

Even the villain is bilingual by accident of history: *silence* is **mauna** (मौन) in Sanskrit and **muon** (無音) in Japanese. Two cultures, one enemy, almost one word.

Her iconography carries the film's music: Saraswati holds the **veena**; Benzaiten holds the **biwa**. Two lutes, one goddess — a duet waiting 1,300 years to be played. And both musical worlds meet on **pentatonic ground**: raga Hamsadhvani ("the swan's cry" — the swan is her mount) on the Indian shore, the miyako-bushi scale on the Japanese shore.

Cross-culture is not this film's costume. It is the premise, the villain, the music, and the ending.



Title treatment — the river of light between a swan and a dragon.

MEERA IYER

17 · Chennai — "the girl who edits what she cannot play"

MEERA
17 year old
South Indian girl



Character sheet — main design. Teal kurti over jeans; her grandmother's swan-headed Saraswati veena; headphones worn like armour.

A Carnatic prodigy who stopped playing the day her grandmother-guru died mid-lesson. Grief made her precise and sarcastic; music became something she *edits* instead of something she *plays*. Her 2 a.m. lo-fi tracks are secretly built on one sample — her grandmother's last recording — looped so it never has to end.

Arc. From editing the past to playing the present: Meera's journey is learning that a tradition is not a recording to preserve but a river to step into. The film's emotional climax is not the goddess's rescue — it is Meera improvising, live, past the point where her grandmother's lesson was cut short.

INSTRUMENT Saraswati veena (heirloom; custom swan-head scroll)

SKILL Carnatic ragas; beat-making; absolute pitch

FLAW Perfectionism as armour; won't improvise

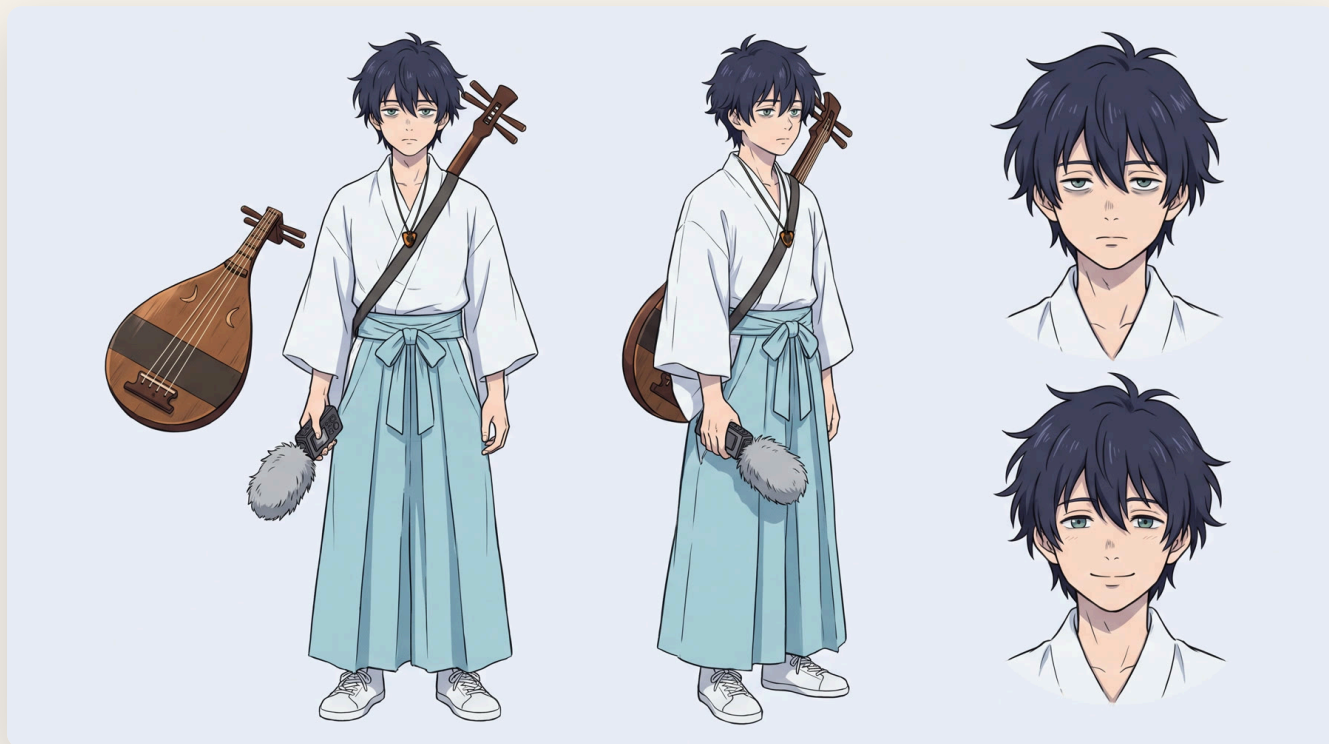
DETAIL Tunes the veena nightly — without playing it

LANGUAGES Tamil, English; zero Japanese

VA DIRECTION Dry wit over a wound

KAITO AMAMIYA

17 · Enoshima — "the boy who records what no one hears"



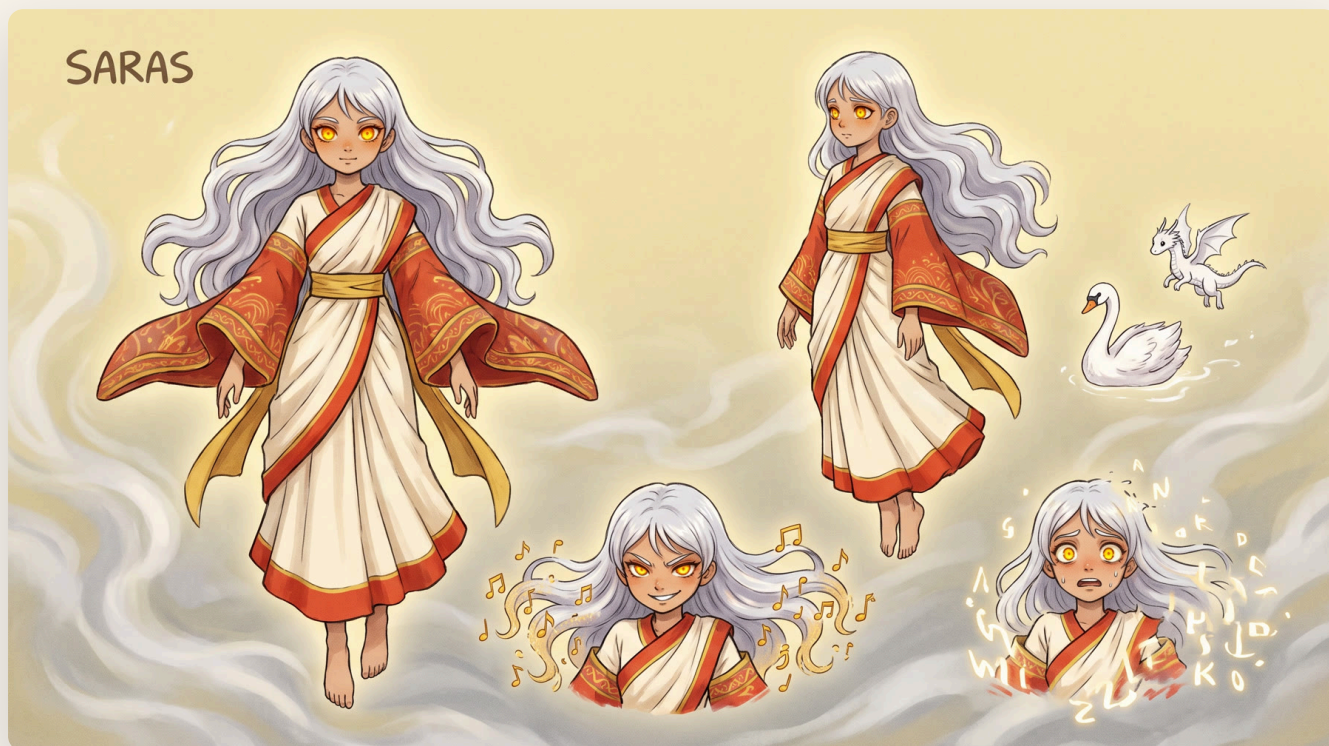
Character sheet — main design. Shrine-attendant whites and asagi-blue hakama over sneakers; field recorder in hand, biwa on back.

Heir to a tiny Benzaiten shrine, Kaito practises the biwa the way you take out the rubbish: dutifully, on Tuesdays. His real devotion is field recording — he believes places have voices, and his archive has names like "*#47: the vending machine that hums in E.*" One dawn he uploads the sound of the shrine before anyone wakes. Meera finds it.

Arc. From performing duty to meaning it: Kaito wants to leave for a sound-engineering school in Tokyo, and the film lets that wish stay true — what changes is that he finally *hears* what his family has been keeping alive. The boy who archives sounds becomes the first person in decades to give the goddess a new one.

INSTRUMENT	Old lacquered biwa (shrine heirloom)
SKILL	Field recording; mixing; patience
FLAW	Politeness as distance; never says "I want"
DETAIL	Bows to rooms after recording them
LANGUAGES	Japanese; textbook English fragments
VA DIRECTION	Quiet, wry; thaws by degrees

SARAS *the goddess with two names*



Saraswati / Benzaiten as she survives today: a girl-shaped remainder. Sari drape × kimono sleeves; swan and dragon; edges dissolving into notes.

Imperious, funny, secretly terrified. She remembers the veena's fingering but not her mother-river's name; she speaks in a tumble of Tamil, Japanese and Sanskrit and acts as the leads' translator — when she is strong enough. She strengthens only when her two shores *sound together*. A neighbourhood child's strawberry-candy offering makes her cry.

MAUNA (मौन / 無音) — the Silence. Not a villain: an accumulation. Every unplayed record, every language dying, every lesson cut short, pooled into an elegant faceless figure whose face is a single white disc — *a whole rest, waiting*. It cannot be destroyed, only answered: the final chord of the film includes its rests. In the last shot, it is sitting in the audience.



Concept board — Mauna in the abandoned concert hall: melancholy, not horror.

Three acts, one raga

Act I Two Notes

A dried riverbed in Rajasthan; wind where a river sang. Chennai: Meera's 2 a.m. mixes. Enoshima: Kaito's dawn recording. The sounds meet in her headphones and **resonate** — and a goddess wakes in both places at once, flickering like a signal split between two receivers. She conscripts them, cackling and translating: *"You made me remember my hands. Now help me remember the rest."*

Act II Learning to Listen

Saras strengthens only when her two shores sound together — so they practise across time zones, phone propped on a water tank, a shrine bell as a metronome. Meera must *play* (not edit); Kaito must *mean it* (not perform). Meanwhile the Silence spreads: a Chennai kutcheri goes mute mid-beat; a Kamakura festival stops ringing. An India–Japan friendship festival brings Meera's school ensemble to Enoshima — the meeting is a comedy of bows and namastes with no shared language. On the shrine steps, their first true duet makes Saras

solid enough to touch. Then Mauna swallows the festival's sound entirely — and Saras with it, mid-laugh.

Act III The Bridge Raga

The only place thin enough to reach her: **Triveni Sangam**, where the invisible river joins the visible two — on **Vasant Panchami**, Saraswati's own festival day. On the confluence at dusk, veena and biwa play the Bridge Raga into absolute silence: the film's sound drops to nothing, and we watch two teenagers play what we cannot hear. The turn is not defeating silence but **including** it — the rests become part of the music, Mauna takes its seat as the audience it always was, and the invisible river ignites with light. Saras returns — not as she was, but as what they made: one goddess, two names, one song.

Coda

Neither of them speaks the other's language yet. They don't need to. Over the credits: the "Two Shores" arrangement — her beats, his field recordings, both lutes.

The world before the song



PROLOGUE — the dried Saraswati. "Long ago, a river sang here."



RESONANCE — her grandmother's veena answers a sound from 6,000 km away.



MAUNA — the Silence takes a Chennai festival mid-drumbeat; colour drains, petals freeze.

Two shores, meeting



CHENNAI — golden hour on the rooftop: the first note Meera plays in a year.



ENOSHIMA — blue hour at the shrine: Kaito's one dutiful note, ringing longer than it should.



THE MEETING — namaste, bow, repeat; Saras, invisible to everyone else, in tears laughing.

The score is the plot 音楽 = 物語

A film about listening must be composed, not just scored. Three sound-worlds, one bridge.

The Bridge Raga. The Indian shore sings raga **Hamsadhvani** — "the cry of the swan", the swan being Saraswati's own mount. The Japanese shore answers in the **miyako-bushi** scale of koto strings and biwa songs. Both are pentatonic; the score builds its central melody from the tonic and fifth the two scales share, then teaches each side to borrow the other's colours — the film's thesis in musical form. The duet the entire story tunes toward is **veena × biwa**: two descendants of one iconography, separated for thirteen centuries.

Three layers.

- **Classical:** veena, biwa, tanpura, mridangam, taiko, nadaswaram, shakuhachi — played straight, with respect.
- **Contemporary:** Meera's lo-fi beats and Kaito's field recordings — the kids' own languages, sampled into the score itself.

- **Silence:** composed rests. Mauna's scenes remove sound layer by layer — the audience learns to dread, then to hear, quiet.

The set pieces. A time-zone practice montage cut to a shared metronome; the shrine-steps first duet where Saras becomes touchable; the festival massacre where a full matsuri is muted in four seconds; and a finale performed *into* absolute silence — the theatre itself goes quiet with the characters, and the music returns note by note, rests included.

Model. A Carnatic-fusion palette in the spirit of India's great film composers meeting the intimate electronic scoring tradition of modern Japanese animation — one score, commissioned as a genuine India-Japan collaboration, with songs recorded in Tamil, Japanese and Sanskrit.

Sound-first direction. Key scenes are boarded to playback, not scored after picture — the animation breathes with the raga's tala cycles and the biwa's silences, in the tradition of the best music-driven anime.

Two palettes, one light 色彩設計



India in warmth, Japan in coolness — and the goddess in the gold both share. Chennai plays in turmeric, vermillion and sea-green with kolam geometry in its light; Enoshima in indigo, asagi and moon silver with seigaiha waves in its clouds. Sound is visible: music moves through both worlds as ink-in-water ripples — gold for the veena, indigo for the biwa — so that when the two colours braid, the audience sees the duet. Mauna is the absence of all of it: desaturation, stillness, one white disc.

Craft lineage. Direction that trusts small gestures and diegetic sound, in the lineage of Naoko Yamada; painted skies and light that make geography romantic, in the lineage of Makoto Shinkai; musical sequences that melt realism when the raga takes over, in the lineage

of Masaaki Yuasa. Hand-drawn 2D characters over painterly watercolour-gouache backgrounds; effects animation (ripples, river-light, pearls) as traditional 2D with digital compositing.

Why anime. Only animation can show sound as a living thing, age a goddess between frames, and hold a 40-second silent close-up of two teenagers playing instruments we cannot hear — and make it the loudest moment of the year.

Series potential. The deity table on page 3 is a map: every migrated god is an episode. *The River Remembers* opens a two-country mythology with room for a 12-episode expansion (working title: *The Gods Who Crossed the Sea*).



SARAS MATERIALIZES — gold and indigo answering each other; the ghost instruments she can no longer hold.

Teach the silence to listen



THE DUET — swan of gold, dragon of indigo: the Bridge Raga pushes back the storm of pearls.



VASANT PANCHAMI AT TRIVENI SANGAM — the invisible river ignites; one goddess, two names, one song.

Rooted, not costumed. Real shared history (Saraswati→Benzaiten), real geography (the lost river, Enoshima), real music theory — depth for both audiences, no tourism.

Two home markets, one heart. A Chennai heroine and an Enoshima hero with equal weight; a language barrier that becomes the film's romance of listening.

Song-driven set pieces built for theatrical sound — including a finale that dares total silence in a packed cinema.

Expandable mythology. One film — and a map of sequels already drawn by history itself.

Accompanying video. A ~2-minute concept teaser (16:9, 1080p, stereo, English narration with Japanese and English subtitles) accompanies this proposal, visualizing nine key shots of the film, narrated by Saras. All visuals are AI-assisted concept art produced for this submission.

Rights & respect. All characters, story, designs and artwork are original to this proposal. Mythological figures and traditional musical forms are public cultural heritage, treated with research and respect; the production plan includes Indian and Japanese cultural and religious consultants at every stage. No third-party footage, music, or IP is used.